

ACT Prep · Week 2 · Roots & Formulas

Ten new word roots, this week's rules and formulas, and a review of your earlier roots.

Word roots

Roots are the building blocks of words. When you meet a word you don't know on the ACT, break it into parts: the root usually gives you enough of the meaning to answer. Your list grows every week; each new sheet adds roots and reviews the ones before.

sub- UNDER

- **submerge**: to put under water
- **subordinate**: ranked under; less important
- **subway**: a train that runs underground

A **subordinate** clause, like "which was built in 1888," sits under the main sentence and can't stand alone.

ject THROW

- **subject**: what a sentence is about
- **project**: to throw forward
- **interject**: to throw a remark in between

Find the **subject** before you choose the verb.

temp / tempor TIME

- **tense**: the time a verb shows
- **temporary**: lasting a short time
- **contemporary**: from the same time

Verb **tense** tells you when; keep it steady unless the time really changes.

mod MEASURE, MANNER

- **modify**: to change the manner of
- **modifier**: a word that describes another
- **moderate**: within a sensible measure

Put a **modifier** right next to the word it describes.

pro- FOR, FORWARD

- **pronoun**: a word that stands for a noun
- **propel**: to push forward
- **prologue**: words that come before the story

A **pronoun** stands in for a noun: "Rosa" becomes "she."

junct / join JOIN

- **conjunction**: a word that joins ideas
- **juncture**: a point where things join
- **adjoin**: to be next to and joined with

The FANBOYS words are **conjunctions**: they join sentences together.

clud / clus CLOSE, SHUT

- **conclude**: to bring to a close
- **include**: to shut in; contain
- **exclude**: to shut out

The ACT often asks which sentence best **concludes** a paragraph.

sequ / secu FOLLOW

- **sequence**: an order that follows
- **consequence**: what follows from an action
- **consecutive**: following one after another

Tense keeps events in **sequence**, so the reader knows what happened first.

tract PULL, DRAW

- **contraction**: words pulled together
- **attract**: to pull toward
- **distract**: to pull attention away

"It's" is a **contraction**: "it is" pulled together.

ced / ceed / cess GO, YIELD

- **antecedent**: what goes before
- **proceed**: to go forward
- **exceed**: to go beyond

A pronoun's **antecedent** is the noun that goes before it.

Five minutes a day: cover the words and say what each root means, then name one word that uses it.

Rules and formulas from this week

This week's grammar rules, plus the Week 1 formulas you used in the warm-up and review. Say each rule out loud, then check yourself with the example.

RULE OR FORMULA	RULE	EXAMPLE
Find the real subject	Cross out "of ..." phrases. The verb matches what's left.	The box of photos sits in the attic.
Either / neither	With or / nor, the verb matches the nearer subject.	Neither the coach nor the players were ready.
There is / there are	"There" is never the subject. Look after the verb.	There are three reasons.
Its vs. it's	it's = it is / it has. its = belongs to it.	The company changed its logo.
Their / there / they're	they're = they are. their = belongs to them. there = a place.	They're parking their truck over there.
Me or I	Drop the other person and listen.	The coach thanked Jada and me.
Who or whom	he → who. him → whom.	The volunteer who organized it (he organized it)
Keep tense steady	Match the time of the sentence and the passage.	Last summer he worked and repaired boats.
Had + past form	Use "had" for the earlier of two past actions.	The crew had finished before the rain started.
Would have	Never "would of." After have / has / had, use the past participle.	would have bought · has frozen · had come
Commas and dashes in pairs	Extra information gets matching marks on both sides.	The lighthouse, built in 1888, still stands.
Colons	Only after a complete sentence. Never after "such as."	We need three things: flour, sugar, and eggs.
No lone commas	No single comma between a subject and its verb.	The students who finished early went home.
Possessives	Plural first, then the apostrophe.	one player's shoe · twelve players' shoes
Slope	$(y_2 - y_1) \div (x_2 - x_1)$	(1, 4) to (3, 10): $6 \div 2 = 3$
Circle area	$A = \pi r^2$	$r = 5 \rightarrow 25\pi$
Percent off	$\text{price} \times (1 - \text{discount})$	\$60, 25% off: $60 \times 0.75 = \$45$
Average (mean)	$\text{sum} \div \text{number of items}$	72, 85, 92 $\rightarrow 249 \div 3 = 83$

Review: Week 1 roots

Keep these fresh. Cover the meanings and say them from memory.

com- / con- **together, with**: composite, consensus, converge
 re- **back, again**: redundant, revise, reject
 fer **carry, bring**: infer, transfer, reference
 vid / vis **see**: evidence, visible, revise
 pre- **before**: predict, precede, preview

pos / pon **put, place**: component, postpone, position
 dict **say, speak**: contradict, predict, verdict
 cis / cid **cut**: concise, precise, incision
 graph **write**: paragraph, graph, biography
 in- / im- / ir- **not**: inaccurate, implausible, irrelevant

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